THIS WEEK'S FILE · FOUNDER FILE #005

THE WEEKEND TONY DINH BUILT TYPINGMIND, FIVE DAYS AFTER THE CHATGPT API

A developer who had already failed with two AI products built a better chat window in five days, sold licences instead of subscriptions, and by his own account now earns well over a million dollars a year. Here is what he did, and what you can copy.

THE FILE

FOUNDER	Tony Dinh, Founder and developer
COMPANY	TypingMind
FOUNDED	2023
HQ	Remote (founder travelling)
SECTOR	AI chat interface (software)
STAGE	Bootstrapped, small team
FUNDING	None reported
MODEL	One-time licences plus team subscriptions

Hello again, and welcome to File #005. Thank you for being here.

On Wednesday 1 March 2023, OpenAI announced that developers could finally use ChatGPT through an API. Plenty of developers had the same thought that day: I could build a nicer chat window. Tony Dinh did something about it. He registered a domain the next day, made slow progress for three days, then gave a whole weekend to it. On Monday 6 March he released it.

By the following Saturday it had made about $22,000.

This week's file is about that weekend, but not only that. It's also about the two AI products that earned him about $100 between them before it, the one decision that made the money possible, and what happened over the next three years as a one-person project slowly became a small company. (All figures are in US dollars, and they are all Tony's own.)

THE SHORT VERSION

- **Who:** Tony Dinh, a Vietnamese-born developer who left a job in 2021 to build products alone.
- **What:** TypingMind, a chat interface for AI models. You bring your own API key, pay the model providers directly for what you use, and pay Tony once for the interface.
- **Why it matters:** it is the cleanest recent example of shipping a thin, useful product the week a new capability appears, and of what that company looks like once it grows.
- **The number to remember:** five. The days between OpenAI announcing the API and Tony releasing TypingMind.

THE FOUNDER

Tony spent about seven years as a software developer. At the end of 2021 he went independent, after discovering the indie hacker world while working alone from home in Singapore. His first products were small tools for developers. DevUtils, a Mac app for developers, was his first to make real money. Black Magic, which let people customise the progress bars on Twitter, grew to about $13,000 a month by late 2022. Then Twitter changed its API pricing and the product was acquired. The lesson he took from that, he has said, is the risk of building on a platform you don't control, which becomes important in this story.

He is also candid about his weak spot. "I really suck at marketing in general," he wrote in October 2025. What he has instead is an audience. By early 2023 he had about 76,000 followers on Twitter, built from years of sharing his work in public.

THE TWO PRODUCTS BEFORE THE ONE THAT WORKED

It's easy to miss this part. Before TypingMind, Tony built two AI products, EmojiAI and AskCommand. Despite a promotional tweet that got about 5,000 likes, the two of them earned about $100 between them. A big audience and a good idea about new technology did not, on their own, make money.

That is a useful detail, because it makes TypingMind look less like luck and more like a better decision.

THE WEEKEND

Here is the timeline, from Tony's own newsletter:

DATE (2023)	WHAT HAPPENED
1 March	OpenAI announces the ChatGPT API. Tony decides the same day to build a better chat interface.
2 March	He registers typingmind.com.
2 to 5 March	Slow progress and low motivation. He worked on it "on and off".

DATE (2023)	WHAT HAPPENED
4 and 5 March	He gives the whole weekend to finishing it.
6 March	Version one is released, five days after the API announcement. First sale the same day, through Lemon Squeezy.
7 to 10 March	Cumulative sales pass about $1,000, then $2,000, $4,000 and $10,000 as he tweets every new feature.
11 March	Product Hunt launch. It ranks first for the day with 902 votes, and cumulative sales reach about $22,000.

A common version of this story says growth came from Reddit and word of mouth. At launch, that's not what happened. By Tony's own account, about 99 percent of the early sales came from his Twitter following. He announced the release there, tweeted each new feature (which doubled as his changelog), and used Product Hunt and his newsletter to amplify it. Reddit and word of mouth matter later, in his telling, but the launch ran on an audience he had already built.

WHAT HE SOLD, AND THE DECISION BEHIND IT

TypingMind is free to try with your own OpenAI key, and then you pay once for a licence. Two decisions made that work.

Bring your own key. Users pay the model provider directly for what they use. That means Tony doesn't pay for anyone's usage, so there is no per-user cost to him.

A one-time licence, not a subscription. The market was already full of subscription wrappers. And Tony, having just lost a product to a platform change, didn't want his income to depend on OpenAI's pricing or goodwill. Because TypingMind started as a static web app, with no backend, database or server, it had no recurring costs. That is what made a one-time price viable. It is the kind of business decision that looks like a pricing choice and is really an architecture choice.

He also offered a self-hosted version, and the product has since added things you'd expect: several models side by side, a knowledge base, and more models from more providers.

HOW IT GREW

The honest answer from his own writing is: slowly, then through other people, then through businesses.

Audience first. The launch came from Twitter. After that, he says, growth came mostly from organic mentions on Reddit and social media, word of mouth, and individuals buying lifetime licences, with sales volume building over time.

Paid ads failed. In November 2024 he said ads and sponsorships gave "terrible" results and that he had stopped. In October 2025, he wrote that a recent ad campaign cost $600 and produced two conversions. He has not found a paid channel that works.

Then teams. As individuals began bringing TypingMind into their workplaces, Tony added a Team product for internal use, and over the following year worked on converting one-off buyers into team customers. By October 2025 he said recurring revenue from the Team version exceeded half of monthly revenue.

That changed the business. By November 2024 he described deals of 1,000 and 3,000 seats. He had spent more than $20,000 on SOC 2, HIPAA, GDPR, security audits and lawyers for contracts. He also says that B2B sales are draining, that he had missed opportunities by not following up with leads, and that he needed a dedicated salesperson. He planned to hire a "Sales Closer" and worked with a design agency on a user-experience audit. In 2025 he posted that he'd welcomed two new teammates, a developer and a designer.

THE NUMBERS

Every figure below is Tony's own. TypingMind doesn't publish processor-verified revenue.

WHEN	WHAT HE SAID	SOURCE
March 2023	About $22,000 in roughly the first week	Newsletter
November 2024	$1 million in revenue over the previous 12 months, from his P&L (not stated whether gross or net). About half of monthly revenue from lifetime licences	Newsletter
Spring 2025	$148,000 in a month, "all-time high" at the time	X post
October 2025	About $130,000 to $160,000 a month, with the Team version over half of it. Described as "more than $1M a year"	Newsletter
December 2025	A secondary tracker reports $210,000 or more and 8,000 new customers in 2025. We could not find Tony's own post	Unverified

Notice what's missing: profit. He gives revenue, not what he keeps. The best we can say is that he describes himself as financially independent, with a lifestyle that hasn't changed much, and that software with no per-user hosting cost tends to have good margins. That is an inference, not a number.

HOW AI FEATURES IN HIS OWN WORK

The product is a front end for AI models, so AI is the thing he sells, not the way he makes it. He says he is "in love with building with AI" and still writes code every day, but his newsletter doesn't name the coding tools he uses, so we won't guess. What he does show is a way of working: a small, stable core, shipped fast, and kept simple enough for one person to maintain.

Try this

Ship the thin version the week something changes. When a new model, API or capability appears, write down the one thing people will immediately find annoying about the official interface, and build only that. Tony took five days.

Check your audience before you build. Two earlier AI products with a big audience made about $100. TypingMind worked because it fixed a daily annoyance for people who were already asking for it.

Pick the pricing that matches your costs. If you can run the product with almost no recurring cost, a one-time price is an option. If you can make the user bring their own key, you don't carry their usage.

Kill a paid channel fast. Tony tried ads, sponsorships and a $600 test campaign. He stopped when they didn't work, and put the time into the product.

Add a team tier once people ask. Don't plan for B2B. Wait until individual buyers start asking for it, then work out what a company would need (security audits, single sign-on, contracts) before you sell.

WHAT COULD GO WRONG

Dependence on the model companies. TypingMind works because other companies' models are good and their APIs are open. A change in access, pricing or terms hits him directly. He knows this, which is why he chose a one-time licence in the first place.

The official apps are free. ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini all have their own interfaces, and they keep improving. TypingMind has to stay meaningfully better, or at least different, for people who already have one for free.

Solo has become a small team. The story starts with one person and a weekend. It now includes a developer, a designer, freelancers, an outside agency and a planned sales hire, which is normal, but it isn't "solo" any more. B2B also brings long sales cycles, security reviews and support, all things he says he doesn't enjoy.

One person's numbers. Everything here comes from Tony's newsletter and posts. He has been unusually open, but nothing has been checked by a third party, and he doesn't give profit.

Marketing. He says he doesn't enjoy it, no paid channel has worked, and most sales come from word of mouth. That works until it stops.

WHAT TO WATCH

1. **Whether the Team business keeps growing** and whether the large seat counts turn into long-term subscriptions.
2. **The official interfaces.** Do the model makers' own apps close the gap that TypingMind exists to fill?

3. **A new product.** In October 2025 he said he might build new products soon. Does he, or does TypingMind stay the whole company?
4. **Whether he publishes profit.** A figure for what he keeps would turn a good story into a verifiable one.

A weekend, a domain, and a decision to charge once. It is a small story, and that is the point.

That's File #005. Thank you for reading it. If it made you think of someone, forward it along, and if there's a founder you'd like to see opened next, tell us at info@aifounderfiles.com. File #006 lands next Sunday.

Where this came from: Tony Dinh's own newsletter and posts, with the figures as he reports them. We have not verified them independently. A note on disclosure: Anthropic makes Claude, the AI assistant that helped research and draft this file, and its models are among those TypingMind connects to. Spotted a mistake? Email info@aifounderfiles.com and we'll correct it.

SOURCES

- Making $22K in 7 days: the story, Tony Dinh's Newsletter (March 2023). news.tonydinh.com
- Nov 2024: My first million!, Tony Dinh's Newsletter. news.tonydinh.com
- Oct 2025 Updates: Code, Money, and Travel, Tony Dinh's Newsletter. news.tonydinh.com
- Tony Dinh on X: $148k revenue last month, all-time high for TypingMind (2025). x.com
- Tony Dinh, Ups and Downs of an Indie Hacker Journey, The Bootstrapped Founder (episode 236). thebootstrappedfounder.com
- How Tony Dinh built TypingMind to $500K revenue in one year, Starter Story. starterstory.com
- How much does TypingMind make? (secondary tracker, figures unverified), I Made Money With AI. imademoneywithai.com
- TypingMind. typingmind.com